

A Beotian Lost in the Making of European Standards

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Between 2005 and 2010, the Beotian I then was discovered the little-seen world of drafting European standards. These were standards for Facility Management services, so-called "recommendation" standards, quite different from "mandatory" ones such as the French NF mark for products.

The creation of a European Facility Management standard - a strict FM standard, meaning one for building-related services in the broad sense - was in the air. Given my experience of major IT infrastructure outsourcing operations, first as IT Director of a large international group and then as an independent consultant, I saw the risk that this standard might one day also be applied to IT and telecommunications outsourcing. The danger would then come from a standard drawn up by specialists in strict FM alone rather than by IT professionals. I persuaded CIGREF to let me represent it before AFNOR in order to take part in drafting this standard. During that drafting process, it was interesting to see clearly that the knowledge gained through major IT outsourcing projects proved entirely applicable and beneficial to strict FM as well.

Drawing up a standard is a long process, more than four years in this case. The process is in fact highly codified: the diagram shows the complexity created by the number of players involved and the successive validation processes at several levels. In summary, starting from a request by an FM service provider in the Netherlands to create a standard, seven European FM standards were eventually produced thanks to numerous back-and-forth exchanges among the users of such standards. Oversight, including compliance with the drafting rules and timelines, is provided by the permanent officers of each country's standardization body, such as AFNOR in France, together with the European Committee for Standardization (CEN). Once approved at European level, they are translated into French standards for application in France.

This process can also quite naturally extend to the global level. Thus today the first two standards, the most general ones, are no more than archives. Since their publication, they have been taken up and incorporated into four ISO standards. Europe was a pioneer.

The analysis of how a standard is drafted - the method - is valuable for business leaders because it tells them what level and type of involvement are desirable in such a process. In fact, if client representatives are absent or weak, the final standard will be unfavourable to them, and they will only realize this when it is applied.

1. Specific Features of the Standard-Setting Process

The whole process is strictly codified: forms, deadlines, methods for appointing rapporteurs, and the percentages allocated to each country for final votes (population size gives very large countries considerable weight). One example of a constraint: it was impossible to amend minutes that were obviously wrong before the "regulatory" one-year deadline had passed.

Neutrality: the permanent officers of the bodies assigned to handle a standard must remain strictly neutral.

The weight of words. A beginner quickly discovers this because standards always begin with definitions.

English is the working language. Thus the word "Facilities" has two meanings: that of physical installations and the more abstract one of services. It is this latter meaning that applies to the standards and ought to be used in translation. But given the common use in French business of the English word "Facilities", the term was not translated. English speakers therefore enjoyed a clear competitive advantage in getting their ideas accepted in working groups. It is therefore permissible to hope that their departure from the European community will make discussions more equal.

The weak representation of clients, who are theoretically the main beneficiaries of standards: for suppliers and, to a lesser extent, consulting firms, standards concern their core business. As a result, they devote significant resources to them, both in number and in quality. For clients, these services are only a tool, and it is difficult for them to devote resources to them, whether in volume or in quality.

An obligation to conclude a working group's output by consensus: the rule for working groups is to produce a text that achieves consensus among all participants. Two consequences follow: lengthy discussions and, in some cases, a weakening of the proposed measures.

An opportunity for participants to broaden their networks: at the time, two-day working meetings were not held remotely but in turn in a European capital. Participants were always very well received by the host country. As a result, after two or three meetings, business relationships or simply friendships could develop.

Critical analysis of standards: when draft standards reached the stage of approval and the collection of possible comments at country level, and especially after consolidation at CEN level before finalization, discussions took place among the people who had worked on drafting these standards. It is easy to imagine how difficult it was

for them to rework the texts. The influence of the permanent CEN officer, with the overriding requirement of impartiality, is then crucial, since that person must ensure a reasoned response to every comment.

2. A Few Recommendations

For clients of standardized services

Clients conduct major FM operations only once every three or four years.

They are in a weak position compared with suppliers or consulting firms, since those actors deal with the subject very frequently.

Clients should therefore:

- join forces to pool costs, for example through professional associations, so that, like the other stakeholders, they have qualified and seasoned representatives in the working groups throughout the entire process of drafting the standard.

- use the resulting standards to obtain fair contracts from suppliers. A supplier can hardly disregard recommendation standards. In particular, in an invitation to tender the client may stipulate that the standards must be applied.

- make sound use of competent consultants, including those who took part in drafting these standards.

In this case, in FM, suppliers greatly preferred to be paid for the resources deployed rather than to commit themselves to results. It was therefore necessary to fight to restrict as far as possible payment based on means employed, so as not to create a lasting imbalance in the supplier-client relationship.

For FM suppliers

The benefit of following the drafting process from the outset is that it can help influence the content of these standards, but also allow advance knowledge of what they will contain. Suppliers can then organize themselves accordingly, develop services that will meet the forthcoming standards, train their teams, and highlight their compliance-related capabilities.

For FM consulting firms

They can show clients that they are ahead of their competitors and able to help clients anticipate developments.

3. Conclusion

The drafting of a standard is therefore a long and surprising process of highly structured international collective intelligence. An in-depth survey among user groups on the actual use and contribution of these standards would probably be instructive.

Guy Le Pechon

Boxes

FM: Facilities Management

CIGREF: Club Informatique des Grandes Entreprises Francaises

AFNOR: Association Francaise de Normalisation. The standards mentioned in the article can be found on AFNOR's online shop. For example: guidelines on how to develop facility management agreements.

CEN: European Committee for Standardization

ISO: International Organization for Standardization

A reading recommendation

An article describing the value of standards for businesses: "Boards of Directors: Standards and Certification" by Danielle Huet-Kuo, excerpted from the book *The World and Governance of Mid-Sized Companies* (video), published by L'Harmattan, with the author of this newsletter article coordinating its production.

An illustration

FLOW DIAGRAM BETWEEN STANDARD-SETTING ORGANIZATIONS

Flow diagram between standard-setting organizations